river for 300 years or more before it became the Magadhan prince's place of functioning. Fortifications of mud were first erected around Ujjayini in the seventh century BCE, and in about the sixth century BCE the state of Avanti, whose capital Ujjayini was, became a powerful independent kingdom.[4]

The territorial ambitions of this state extended beyond Central India into the Gangetic north. Pradyota, the ruler of Avanti, was a contemporary of Bimbisara, king of Magadha (and father of Ajatashatru, fortifier of Pataliputra). The Avanti-based Pradyota is known to have had designs on Magadha and, in one tradition, attacked Rajagriha, the Magadha capital during Bimbisara's life-time. Apparently it was out of fear of an aggrandizing Pradyota that, later, Ajatashatru strengthened Rajagriha's defences. Subsequently, one of Pradyota's successors conquered the North Indian kingdom of Vatsa, after which a prince of Ujjayini ruled from its capital, Kaushambi. So, the practice of princes administering distant provinces of large states seems to have been fairly common much before Ashoka.

Avanti, though, could not sustain hegemony over Vatsa and, over time, ceased to be an independent kingdom. When this happened is not known, but by the time Bindusara took over the reins of empire the Magadha-based Maurya state assuredly exercised control over it. The emperor's decision to dispatch Ashoka as its viceroy suggests that the Malwa-centred Avanti province, on account of its wealth and links with various parts of India, was strategic for political and commercial reasons.

A trail of sorts can be discerned as Ashoka travelled on his father's orders from Pataliputra to Malwa.

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Ancient India's royalty travelled in style: that is what sculptural representations of large royal processions of chariots and elephants suggest. Some of the earliest such reliefs can be seen at Bharhut in Central India of